



# *Private Screening*

A CINEPHILE'S MAGAZINE

*"Cinema is a matter  
of what's in the frame  
and what's out."*

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*Sundance Kid*

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# ACT 1

## Editor's Note

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I became an unusually patient film viewer at a very young age, thanks to my grandmother's absolute control over the TV remote. The television was almost always tuned to the movie channel, and like the final school bell of the day, the last foreign film aired each night by CCTV was my moment of redemption. Almost without fail, my grandmother would fall asleep before the movie ended, and at last, I could browse through the TV channels freely—this was also how I managed to have something to talk about with my classmates the next day.

One weekend in 2017, the preview in the bottom-left corner of the screen announced the final film of the night: Paolo Sorrentino's *The Great Beauty*. A dull title, I thought, and probably a boring movie too. How would I stay awake until my grandmother nodded off?

But I did. And I liked it—a lot.

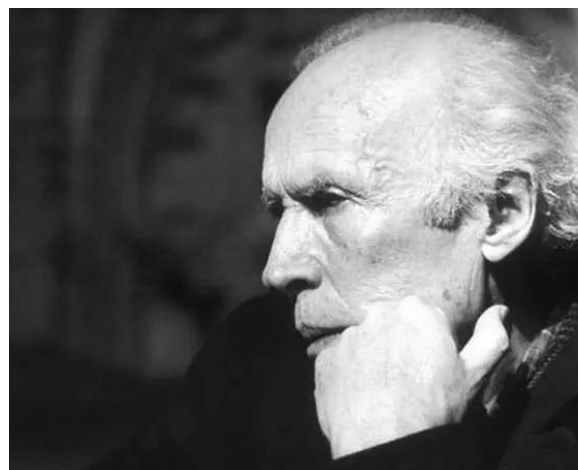
The elusive plot and elliptical dialogues made it hard to summarize, yet I was captivated. The broken reflections of lavish parties, the Roman city in morning light, the Colosseum at sunset, the flamingos before dawn, and countless nocturnal wanderings—this was a film of pure beauty. The next day at noon, I watched the rerun. For the first time, I realized that cinema isn't just about storytelling, like literature. Bad films are like students padding out a dull essay—long-winded and empty. Good films, however, can say a lot with very little. Cinema is “showing”—this is what sets it apart from other arts.





Later, I came across a quote in an interview with Éric Rohmer that echoed my realization:

“Or, la littérature le décrit, la peinture le peint, en le figeant, en l’interprétant, le cinéma montre – par exemple, Nanouk l’Esquimau en train de harponner le morse. C’est une chose qui ne ressemble à rien, qui n’a pas d’équivalent. Jusque-là, il fallait ou bien faire un tableau ou bien décrire. Le fait de pouvoir photographier, le fait de filmer, nous amène à une connaissance du monde fondamentalement différente, et qui entraîne un renversement des valeurs.” (“Literature describes it, painting freezes and interprets it, but cinema shows it—for



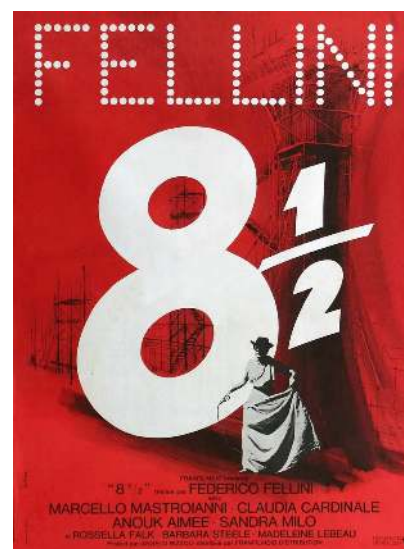
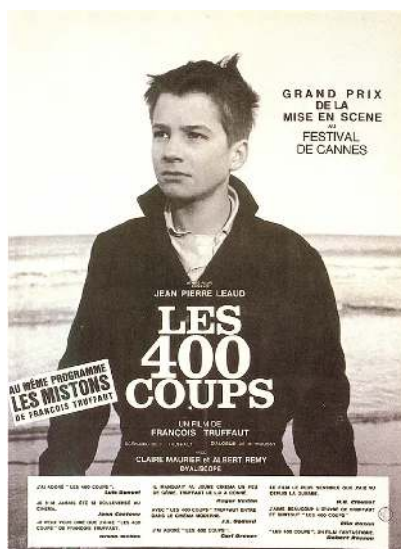
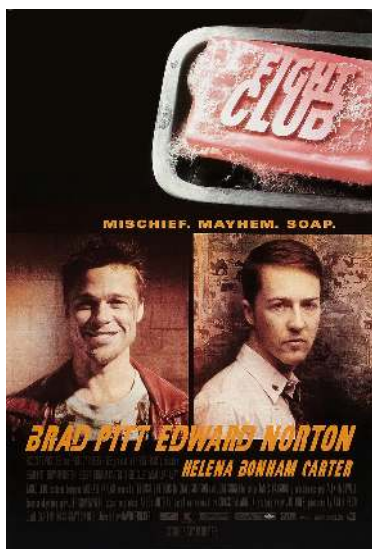
(Éric Rohmer)

example, Nanook of the North harpooning a walrus. It is something incomparable, unlike anything else. Until then, one had to paint it or describe it. The ability to photograph and film brings us to a fundamentally different understanding of the world—one that reverses existing values.”)

It was a beautiful experience. I wanted to see more. After getting my own computer, I started watching films from IMDb’s Top 250. I became a fan of actors like Al Pacino, Robert De Niro, and Marlon Brando, and directors like Martin Scorsese, Quentin Tarantino, and David Fincher. I truly enjoyed their work, but I still saw them as “story films”—films that primarily convey narrative.

So I turned my gaze toward Europe.

I still remember my first viewing of Fellini’s *8½*. As the camera moved, I felt as if I were moving with it, as though I too were taking part in the film’s creation. I wanted to get closer to cinema. I began to explore the classics, and I learned about film theory. I’ve always had the habit of writing film reviews, and now, I’d like to organize them into a collection, a way to clarify my thoughts and share them.



I've always written for my own pleasure, and in this "game," I choose to abide by the rules laid out by Jean Renoir:

"Ne perdez pas de temps à dire du mal des films que vous détestez, parlez plutôt des films que vous aimez et partagez votre plaisir avec les autres." ("Don't waste your time speaking ill of films you hate. Instead, talk about the films you love, and share that joy with others.")

Looking back on the French New Wave—the most glorious era in film history—you'll find that those brilliant directors left behind not only original films but also solid theories and eloquent criticism. Inspired by them, I've selected some post-New Wave films I admire. My reviews focus on film style and cinematic language.







# ACT 2

*It's*

*All the Americans' Fault...*

# Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid





**George Roy Hill**  
**Paul Newman**  
**Robert Redford**  
**Katharine Ross**

# When the Camera Dances, Not Just Records

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**After** watching enough films, you start to realize something critical: once the techniques and theories of cinema reach a certain level of maturity, beautiful visuals, perfect framing, and smooth editing become mere prerequisites. They're no longer what makes a film great—they're just the entry ticket. What sets a film apart is "how" these techniques are deployed, how they're mixed, timed, and most importantly, how intuitively they serve the narrative. Many modern directors tend to overplay their hands, falling into a trap of stylistic overkill. Christopher Nolan, for example, often creates an overwhelming sense of technical brilliance—but not much else. His films are less about vision than about showing off.

George Roy Hill, however, in *Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid*, shows us what real cinematic intuition looks like. His camera doesn't shout; it "dances". It listens to rhythm. It breathes with the characters. And three sequences in particular demonstrate this with astonishing grace.

First, the recurring shootout motif, from the opening standoff to the climactic bursts of gunfire. These scenes are not just about violence—they're about tempo. Hill plays with silence and surprise like a jazz musician with a snare drum. The editing isn't there to shock but to "swing". Gunshots punctuate pauses, and every pull of the trigger is timed not for plot, but for visual syncopation.

Second, Butch riding the bicycle. In any other Western, this would've been cut for tone, dismissed as fluff. But here it becomes one of the most endearing, rhythmically essential sequences. Set to "Raindrops Keep Fallin' on My Head," it completely disrupts genre expectations—intentionally. We're not watching hardened gunslingers anymore; we're watching boys stealing time from fate, spinning wheels in a world closing in.







Third, the Bolivia montage. This is where Hill flexes his editorial genius. A collage of sepia-toned stills and fade transitions charts Butch and Sundance's foreign misadventures. But it does more than move the story forward—it “retextures” the film. It shifts the tone from narrative to memory, giving us a sense of time slipping away. It's more emotionally resonant, and frankly more imaginative, than Coppola's oft-praised baptism montage in “The Godfather”. (Yes, I said it. Sorry, Francis.)

These three moments—the shootouts, the bike ride, the montage—are more than stylish diversions. They are Hill's way of saying:

**A Western doesn't have to be dusty, slow, and male-drenched in pathos. It can glide. It can laugh. It can wink without losing its edge.**

The second element that elevates this film is its genre subversion. The Western gunslinger and the three-person dynamic are both tropes worn thin by cinematic repetition. Yet Hill refreshes both.





The classic gunslinger is mythic—noble, lethal, silent. Here, those traits are split between Butch and Sundance. Butch is the thinker, Sundance the sharpshooter. Together, they form not a legend, but something far rarer in Westerns: believable *humans*. The film never strains for grandeur. It leans into humor, into hesitation, into the joy and absurdity of partnership on the run.

Then comes the three-person ensemble. Traditionally, this would revolve around the woman, with romantic tension at the center. But here, the triangle isn't romantic at all—it's emotional. The real chemistry is between Butch and Sundance. The film dares to put emotional weight on their bond, and in doing so, it subtly inaugurates a cinematic tradition of coded male-male intimacy. Let's be honest: Paul Newman and Robert Redford ride one horse on the run in the dusty west? This could be the sexiest scene in movie history.



After my first viewing, I spiraled down a Western rabbit hole. I watched everything from *The Searchers* to *Unforgiven*. I even started playing *Red Dead Redemption* religiously. I planned to buy a horse. Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid, a Western that made me want to laugh, cry, and become Sadie Adler?

**That's not just a film. That's a damn revolution.**







# RESERVOIR DOGS

**Quentin Tarantino**  
**Harvey Keitel**  
**Tim Roth**  
**Michael Madsen**  
**Steve Buscemi**  
**Chris Penn**  
**Lawrence Tierney**







# DIALOGUE AS BULLET



**Five Total Strangers  
Team Up For The Perfect Crime.  
They Don't Know Each Other's Name.  
But They've Got Each Other's Number.**

Following Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid in this magazine isn't just about chronology—it's cinematic destiny. In 1973, Robert Redford and the Sundance Institute ushered in a new era of American independent auteurs. Two decades later, from that very crucible emerged a former video store clerk with a film so explosive it felt like it had been smuggled out of a crime scene. Quentin Tarantino's *Reservoir Dogs* is not a film about a failed heist—it is a film about the triumph of dialogue.

Watching *Reservoir Dogs* feels like listening to a madman tell a cold joke—every line glints like a blade balanced on the tongue. This isn't a film about action. It's a film where "language" generates action. Tarantino doesn't use dialogue to serve the plot; he uses it to create plot. Especially in the relationship between Mr. White and Mr. Orange, we don't get exposition—we get seduction, tension, myth-making through conversation.



One is a phantom of gangster honor, the other a poetic infiltrator. Their dialogues don't just "move" the story; they "are" the story.

This film understands something most movies forget: characters become real not through backstory, but through the way they speak. Mr. White and Mr. Orange aren't just characters. Their dynamic is the emotional core of the film, evolving not through action, but through incremental trust negotiated via conversation. The bond between them isn't built on shared history, but on spoken trust—not because of what happens, but because of what is said, and what is not.

Tarantino's camera here is remarkably restrained. This is his least flashy film. No split timelines, no anime flashbacks, no stylized carnage à la *Kill Bill*. Instead, we get something closer to theater: one warehouse, a few guns, a few men, and no real names—only color-coded ciphers. This abstraction doesn't dilute emotion; it distills it. The characters become avatars of loyalty, betrayal, and guilt, their identities shaped not by who they are, but by what they say.

This is a film where dialogue is divine. From the "Like a Virgin" dissection to the rant about tipping, from Mr.



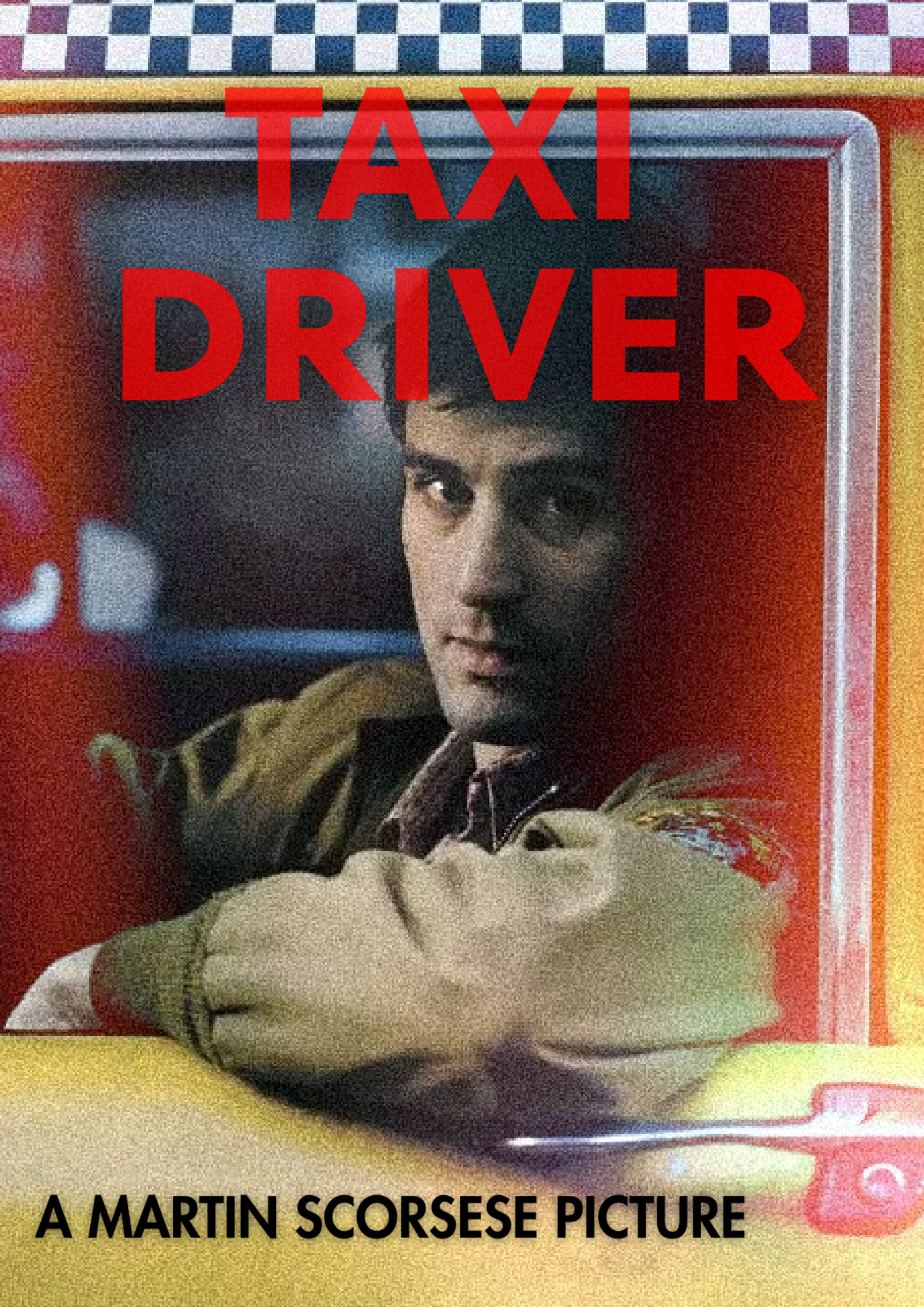
Blonde's psychotic calm to the final whisper between White and Orange—every line leaves residue. Tarantino demolishes the myth that great cinema requires big action.

**He proves that with the right rhythm, a scene of men talking in a room can be more explosive than any car chase.**

What Tarantino inherited from his time at the video store wasn't technique—it was defiance. He believes that cinema belongs to storytellers, not technicians. And *Reservoir Dogs* is the work of a storyteller challenging the limits of language on screen. It's vulgar, violent, and unhinged, yet possesses a kind of spiritual purity: dialogue as creed, characters as gospel, gunfire as benediction.

*Reservoir Dogs* is not just Tarantino's best—it's his most honest. It's the film least corrupted by mythology, least concerned with cool. It's not trying to be a pop culture phenomenon—it simply "is", by nature. And that's why it endures. Not because it was the start of something, but because it was already complete: a stripped-down manifesto for a new kind of cinema.



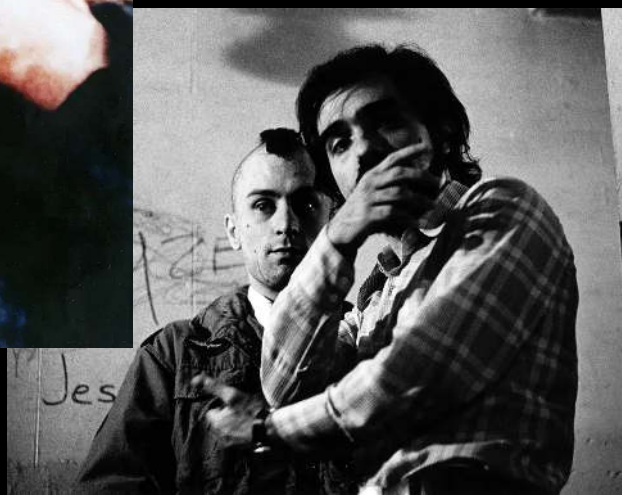
A movie poster for the film 'Taxi Driver'. At the top is a blue and white checkered border. Below it, a man (Travis Bickle) is shown from the chest up, looking out of a taxi window. He has a serious expression and is wearing a brown jacket over a dark shirt. His hands are resting on the dashboard, which is covered with a yellow cloth. A pair of red-tinted aviator sunglasses lies on the dashboard in the lower right. The background outside the window is blurred, showing city lights and a red car. The title 'TAXI DRIVER' is written in large, bold, red capital letters across the top half of the image.

# TAXI DRIVER

**A MARTIN SCORSESE PICTURE**



**ROBERT DE NIRO  
JODI FOSTER  
CYBIL SHEPHERD**



## **A Madman's Diary**

The responsibility for the movie-watching experience doesn't always lie with the director or the actors. Sometimes, it's the viewer—their emotional state, their mental weather—that colors what they see. Watch *Taxi Driver* when you're in a low mood, and it becomes something far more personal, far more dangerous.

This is a first-person film in the truest sense—a cinematic diary of a man descending into madness. For the first thirty minutes, you're wholly immersed. Travis Bickle's New York becomes your own: a city smeared in neon, filled with shadowy figures and unspoken threats. The world looks just as blurry and hollow as it feels on your worst nights. Herrmann's slow, brooding jazz seeps through the streets like smoke, making you feel like you're gliding through this nocturnal purgatory with Travis, staring out the window in mutual silence and disgust.

But then comes a shift. When Travis

**On every street in every city, there's a nobody who dreams of being a somebody.**





## A WALKING CONTRADICTION

attends a cabbie gathering with his fellow drivers, you realize something jarring: this man's isolation isn't just emotional. He is truly cut off, detached from the people around him. And it only gets darker from here.

There are a few moments that make you squirm—not because of what's shown, but because of what's revealed. Travis is not just disillusioned. He is profoundly racist. Scattered shots throughout the film—his gaze at Black passengers, his hand subtly tightening on the steering wheel—hint at deep-seated prejudices. It's quiet but deliberate. Unignorable.

And then comes Betsy. At first, Betsy seems like his way out—a chance for intimacy, for light. But Travis, as she says so piercingly, is “a walking

contradiction.” He wants love but doesn't understand affection. He wants purity but wallows in filth. He brings her to a porn theater on their date. He hates the scum of the city but chooses to become a night driver, placing himself right at the heart of it all. He could escape his loneliness—but instead, he destroys every bridge he builds.

The climactic shootout is often read as cathartic, even redemptive. But let's be clear: Travis does not clean the city, nor does he confront real evil. What unfolds is not justice, but a fantasy of heroism—a twisted myth he constructs to give his existence meaning. Before that, he even plots to assassinate a senator, not because of any political disagreement, but because the senator employs Betsy. For Travis, this is all about reclaiming her, liberating her from a freedom she already owns.

It's disturbing. But it's masterfully told. Even when Travis is hailed as a hero by the end, the unease doesn't fade. If anything, it worsens. He's still alone. Still fantasizing. Still armed. And as the screen cuts to black, we're left with a chilling question: next time, will his bullets find the “right” targets—or not?







What keeps us tethered to this powder keg of a character is Robert De Niro. His Travis is magnetic, confusing, repulsive, and, paradoxically, heartbreaking. His portrayal captures the very essence of loneliness—how it festers into something sinister. Every monologue, especially the iconic “You talkin’ to me?” sequence, is delivered with such haunting conviction that you can’t tell if he’s performing or unraveling. His eyes, his posture, his muttering—De Niro doesn’t act Travis. He becomes him.

This is not a feel-good film, but it feels real. It reminds you that loneliness can twist even the most well-meaning people into someone unrecognizable. And in a weird way, Travis becomes a mirror—an extreme one, sure, but a reflection all the same.

"You talkin' to me?"

"You talkin' to me?"

"You talkin' to me?"

"Then who the hell else are you talkin' to?"

"You talkin' to me? Well, I'm the only one here."

"Who the fuck do you think you're talkin' to?"

"Oh yeah? OK."





# ANNIE HALL





# **Woody Allen**

# **Diane Keaton**



**This guy goes to a psychiatrist  
and says,  
'Doc, my brother's crazy, he  
thinks he's a chicken.'  
The doctor says, 'Why don't you  
turn him in?'**





**The guy says,  
'I would, but I need the eggs.'**

# ***Love, Neuroses, and the Art***

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## **Before**

Annie Hall, Woody Allen's films were mostly packed with venomous jokes, rapid-fire one-liners, and endless intellectual name-dropping. Don't get me wrong—I liked those jokes. I even stole a few for casual use. But after watching enough of them, you start to feel the fatigue: it's a parade of cleverness that begins to feel smug, as if Allen were winking at the audience while showing off his bookshelf. That smugness, that neurotic superiority, made his films feel like long stand-up routines wrapped in movie form.

Then came *Annie Hall*. And suddenly, Allen broke through his own persona. This film marked the moment he achieved a balance between biting wit and emotional sincerity. Here, for once, he didn't just riff on his neuroses—he told a story. A complete one. *Annie Hall* is the point where Allen stopped being just the clever jester of Jewish Manhattan and became a serious filmmaker.

At the core of *Annie Hall* is “breakup”. It's a love story told in reverse, and sideways, and sometimes diagonally. What's brilliant is that all this narrative freedom never becomes confusing. Instead, it makes the film feel alive—constantly shifting, questioning itself, correcting its own assumptions. This is Allen's signature style at its most evolved: neurotic, self-deprecating, and intellectually playful, but now with genuine heart. And it's all stitched together through the electric chemistry between Allen and Diane Keaton, who gives a performance so natural and disarming it almost feels improvised.





*So what? You're what Grammy Hall would call a real Jew.*

*Thank you.*





Watching *Annie Hall*, I was reminded of *Love in the Time of Cholera*. Márquez's novel tried to touch on everything love could possibly be—infatuation, obsession, endurance, misunderstanding—and in a similar way, Allen's film feels like an encyclopedia of romantic entanglement. Alvy doesn't just fall in love with Annie; he tries to understand her, analyze her, categorize her... and in doing so, alienates her.

There are moments in the film that deepened my personal recognition that "hell is other people." Remember my personal recognition that "hell is other people." Remember when Alvy forces Annie into psychotherapy while refusing to go himself? Or when they're trying to cook lobsters and it's sweet, but you can already feel the cracks? Or when Alvy flies across the country to Los Angeles, not to support Annie, but to drag her back to his own comfort zone? These are not just scenes of romantic dysfunction—they're little essays on how love can be sabotaged by ego, control, and the inability to let someone else "be".



At times, “Annie Hall” feels like a horror film for introverts: the fear of being truly known, and still not understood. But here’s where Allen earns our respect. He doesn’t leave us in despair. In one of the most touching final scenes in romantic comedy history, Alvy tells a joke:

**“This guy goes to a psychiatrist and says, ‘Doc, my brother’s crazy—he thinks he’s a chicken.’**

**And the doctor says, ‘Why don’t you turn him in?’  
The guy says, ‘I would, but I need the eggs.’”**

**That’s love, he says. Irrational, maddening,  
inexplicable—but we need the eggs.**

It tells us that love isn’t meant to be perfect or even fully understandable. It’s meant to be experienced, endured, and sometimes even laughed at. Annie Hall doesn’t tell you to believe in soulmates or chase destiny. It tells you to live through the awkwardness, the therapy sessions, the cross-country flights, the lobster spills—and maybe, somehow, come out the other side with enough memories to make it worthwhile.

After watching Annie Hall, I don’t fear relationships as much. I’ve stopped trying to explain love. Maybe the point isn’t to understand it, but to participate in it. I also need the eggs.





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# ACT 3

THIS MUST BE EUROPE.



# PARIS, TEXAS

An eerie, sad story whose meaning disappears over the vast horizon as if on a highway heading away through the desert.

by Guardian





# A LOVE LETTER TO THE PAIN

I once watched *Paris, Texas* after a breakup, and I cried until I could barely breathe. Now, rewatching it in a much calmer state, I find myself surprisingly short on words. Maybe this is what healing does—it softens the sharp edges, but it also takes away the desperate need to explain.

This film has received its fair share of criticism, and some of it isn't entirely off the mark. At a glance, *Paris, Texas* is the story of a man who impregnated a teenage girl, was consumed by jealousy and rage, drove his wife away, disappeared and left his son to be raised by his brother and sister-in-law for four years. Then, by some twist of fate, he reappears, uproots his son from the only home he's known, insists on reuniting

him with the mother—now a sex worker—and walks away, alone.

From a detached, pragmatic view, this might seem like the narrative of a selfish man causing chaos and vanishing when it gets too hard. And yet, that's not the film I saw. For me, this is a deeply “anti-romantic” film—one that doesn't attempt to sell us the dream, but rather lays bare the unfiltered mess of love. It doesn't shy away from the worst we can become in the name of intimacy. Watching it, I recognized in Travis not just a character but a mirror: we've all done things in relationships we regret. We've all, at times, let jealousy, insecurity, or fear dictate our actions. And no matter how many love stories we've watched or advice columns we've read, when it's our turn, we still fall into the same old traps.

That's what makes “*Paris, Texas*” so devastatingly honest. Travis doesn't speak for the first half of the film. He drifts through desolate

*“I asked at the end how many of them had seen it for the first time...It was something special and something that escaped what they know.”*





landscapes, haunted and mute. But as he begins to open up—slowly, hesitantly—we start to understand. His silence wasn't emptiness; it was grief calcified. We learn the backstory not through exposition, but through quiet gestures and tender unraveling.

And then we reach the mirror camera doesn't flinch, the music doesn't rise—it just lets the rawness sit there. We don't get catharsis. We get recognition.

This film doesn't offer solutions. It doesn't tell you how to be better in love, or how to keep the people you love from leaving. It simply shows you what it looks like when someone tries—too late, perhaps, and not quite right—to make peace with their past. After watching it we just take our past with us and fall into the lonely distance with Travis accompanied by the sound of sobbing guitar strumming.

Watching *Paris, Texas* is not a comforting experience. It's not a warm cup of tea or a romantic sunset. It's like stumbling across an old letter from someone you once loved and reading it in the dark, long after the wound has scarred. But that's what makes it so powerful.

Not every film needs to be a beautiful journey. Some, like *Paris, Texas*, are meant to be “necessary” ones—painful, profound, and quietly unforgettable.



*“Travis is a unique character, but in a strange way, easy to identify with. Especially today, where loneliness is a big, different topic than 40 years ago.”*





# *Last Tango in Paris*











# MARLON BRANDO'S PARIS

In a *Once Upon a Time in Hollywood* press interview, Brad Pitt was once asked: "If you could go back and live inside one film, which would it be?" His answer was swift and simple—*Last Tango in Paris*. I think that would be my answer too.

There's something haunting and elusive about Bertolucci's Paris—dreamlike, but not in a romanticized postcard way. This is not the Paris of Hemingway cafés or midnight strolls by the Seine. This is a foggier, more intimate Paris, filmed through windows streaked with rain, stairwells that smell of old cigarette smoke, and empty apartments that feel like the inside of someone's wounded psyche. It's a city suspended in mourning and lust, a ghost town where memories echo louder than footsteps.

**But more than anything else, this is "Marlon Brando's Paris".**

In my usual way of evaluating films, I rarely give performances more weight than directorial vision or cinematic language. Actors may dazzle, but they usually remain within the world a director creates. *Last Tango in Paris* is an exception. In this film, Brando doesn't just play a character—he takes control of the entire atmosphere. It's not just that he commands the screen; it's that he seems to "possess" the film, bending its emotional core to his will.

Brando, by this point in his career, had moved beyond the myth of stardom. He was weathered, raw, radiating a kind of tragic masculinity—intimate yet unreachable. His presence in *Last Tango in Paris* is almost mythological: a god who has been dethroned and now walks among men with rage and tenderness coiled tightly beneath his skin. The brilliance of Bertolucci's vision lies in giving this persona the perfect habitat—a film as unfiltered and volatile as Brando himself.

His monologues in the film—especially the one beside his wife's corpse—are not “performed” in any traditional sense. They erupt. It's difficult to tell where Brando ends and the character begins. At times, the emotional nakedness is so stark, so immediate, that it feels like we've stumbled into something we weren't meant to witness. Reportedly, Brando himself was furious after seeing the final cut, accusing Bertolucci of stealing his feelings. Perhaps he was right. But as viewers, we can only be grateful for the theft—because what he gave us is something few actors ever dare to: a piece of himself, not as a character, but as a man.

Then there's the tango.

The film's title is no accident. Gato Barbieri's saxophone-heavy score doesn't accompany the movie so much as “dance” with it. The fluid camera work—drifting, circling, recoiling—moves in rhythm with the music, and with the emotional tempo of its characters. The camera doesn't just show Paris—it “sways” through it, like a partner in some doomed, drunken tango. It's a visual style that mirrors the narrative itself: two strangers locked in an embrace, stumbling toward something they can't name.

And there's a cruelty to this embrace. The film doesn't flinch. It shows us desire in its purest, least adorned form—not tender, not sweet, but brutal, desperate, sometimes ugly. For some, the film is unbearable. But there is honesty in that discomfort. *Last Tango in Paris* isn't a film about love; it's a film about the absence of it. About what happens when intimacy becomes a kind of violence—against the self, and against others.

You could argue whether Bertolucci crossed lines, and people have. But from a purely cinematic standpoint, *Last Tango in Paris* is a rare thing: a film that bleeds, sweats, aches. It exists in the raw, in the real, and in the fractured.

Brando once said, “An actor is at most a poet and at least an entertainer.” In *Last Tango in Paris*, he's neither. He's a man, caught mid-fall, and we're lucky—and a little cursed—to fall with him in this movie.



When you see a love story, it's only a movie. When you feel it with every nerve in your body, it's a masterpiece.





# THE GREAT BEA

**“The most important thing I discovered a few days after turning 65 is that I can’t waste any more time doing things I don’t want to do.”**



## A MIRROR FRAMED IN SPLENDOR

When I first watched *The Great Beauty*, I didn’t really understand what it was about. The narrative seemed elusive, meandering like a dream. And yet, I was instantly drawn to it—not for the plot, but for its visuals, for the way the camera seemed to glide through Rome like a sigh, the way each frame shimmered like a line from a prose poem. I watched it again. And again. Somewhere between those viewings, I became a cinephile. Or perhaps it’s more accurate to say: this film defined my cinematic sensibility.

**“The trains at our parties are the best in Rome. They’re the best ’cause they go nowhere.”**

# UTY



Years later, after several rewatches and deeper reflection, I came to understand that this is not merely a film about decadence, but about a man at the top of society looking back on his life, searching for beauty—not the kind one can touch, but the kind that lingers just out of reach. Even after watching hundreds, maybe thousands of films since, I still find myself returning to *The Great Beauty* every year. It has become a ritual. A private pilgrimage to something I now consider a masterpiece.

What fascinates me most is how the film so delicately balances surface and substance. On the surface, it is drenched in opulence: lavish parties, glittering lights, couture, art, the Vatican, the endless Roman skyline. It's a world of illusions, of artifice so dazzling that it becomes a kind of art in itself. Sorrentino wraps the film in aesthetic perfection—a beautiful shell.

But beneath that shell lies something far more human, even tender. Jep Gambardella, our elegant, aging





protagonist, is not just a master of the Roman nightlife. He is also a man burdened by quiet griefs and unresolved longing. There's his first love—the woman who left him but confessed, in her death, to having loved only him all her life. And he, in turn, has loved her always. This tragic symmetry isn't the stuff of grand romantic dramas—it's the pain of ordinary people, the ache of what-could-have-beens. For all his social grace and performative wit, Jep is not immune to the emotional chaos we all face.

"They ask me why I didn't write another novel. But look around here... this is my life: nothing. Flaubert wanted to write a novel about nothing — and failed. Should I succeed?"

One of the film's most brilliant moments is a subtle contrast: Jep, ever the connoisseur of appearances, instructs his lover at a funeral on how to express sorrow "appropriately." Yet when faced with the death of a lifelong friend, he breaks down in uncontrollable sobs as he helps carry the casket. The man who wrote the rules of grief cannot follow them himself. Here lies the conflict at the heart of *The Great Beauty*: the tension between social ritual and authentic feeling, between performing life and living it.

All his life, Jep has chased "la grande bellezza", the great beauty. He has seen art, grandeur, sacred ceremonies, and collapsing ruins. He has witnessed the sublime in cathedrals and in performance. But in the end, his answer—what he chooses to show us as the great beauty—is a memory of a quiet morning at the seaside, watching the beautiful body of his love. It is a moment that has no grandeur, no artistic pretension. Just two people, light, and time. He strips everything away, and in that bareness, finds peace.

This return to simplicity is the film's quiet triumph. It speaks not just to Jep, but to us—the viewers, the dreamers, the film lovers. Life is not only made of grandeur and spectacle. It is in the fleeting, the modest, the genuine. We may strive for aesthetic perfection, but we must also learn to live.

These are the insights of 19 year old me. I'm certain that as I grow older, I will continue to revisit *The Great Beauty*, and it will continue to speak to me in new ways. That, perhaps, is its truest magic: it does not age. It reflects back at us what we are ready to see.

***“THIS IS HOW IT ALWAYS ENDS. WITH  
DEATH. BUT FIRST THERE WAS LIFE, HIDDEN  
BENEATH THE BLAH, BLAH, BLAH...  
IT’S ALL SETTLED BENEATH THE  
CHITTER-CHATTER AND THE NOISE. SILENCE  
AND SENTIMENT. EMOTION AND FEAR. THE  
HAGGARD, INCONSTANT FLASHES OF  
BEAUTY. AND THEN THE WRETCHED  
SQUALOR AND MISERABLE HUMANITY...  
LET THIS NOVEL BEGIN. AFTER ALL...  
IT’S JUST A TRICK. YES, IT’S JUST A TRICK.”***





UN FILM DE  
**ALMODÓVAR**  
**ANTONIO**  
**BANDERAS**

# Pain & Glory

*“Pain and Glory’... is a deeply personal film reflecting an autumnal stage in the filmmaker’s career...*

*Despite its somber tone, it retains flashes of Almodóvar’s characteristic boldness and honesty.”*

**by The New Yorker**

**A Masterclass in  
Autobiographical Cinema Without Arrogance**

This film follows *The Great Beauty* in our magazine’s sequence, and quite fittingly so. And now, *Pain and Glory*. Obviously, this is another film in the tradition of *8½*—a director’s self-reflection, a journey through memory and present pain. In recent years, there’s been no shortage of these semi-autobiographical memory films made by aging auteurs. But this genre has a trap that many fall into: self-importance.

Take Sorrentino’s *The Hand of God*, for instance. I had high expectations. After the success of *The Great Beauty*, I had come to regard Sorrentino as the true successor of Italian Neorealism. So when I heard he was working on his own *8½*, I was thrilled. But after watching it, I was greatly disappointed. Most of the film is about the pursuit of art, which makes it very difficult for the audience to emotionally connect it with their own adolescence. Many people felt it was



Directed by Pedro Almodóvar

Antonio Banderas, Asier Etxeandia, Penélope Cruz, Leonardo Sbaraglia,  
Julieta Serrano, Nora Navas

Producer Agustín Almodóvar executive producer Esther García

composer Alberto Iglesias editor Teresa Font director of photography Jose Luis Alcaine a.e.c.

written and directed by Pedro Almodóvar

# Pain & Gloria





pretentious—and frankly, I agree.

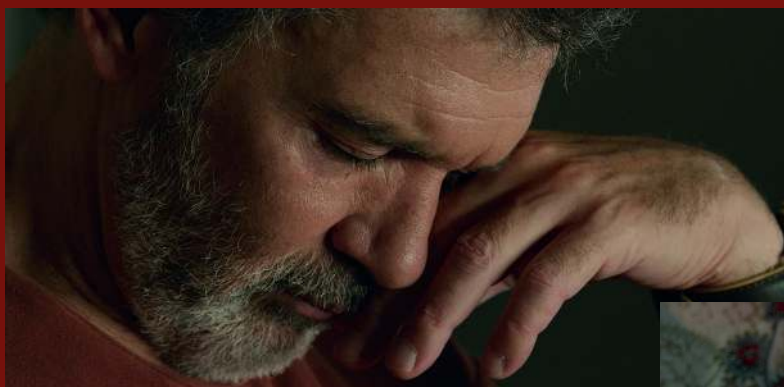
Almodóvar, on the other hand, after a lifetime of making erotically charged, stylistic films, surprises us with a quiet, introspective story based on his own life. *Pain and Glory* sets a benchmark for how this genre can be done right.

Firstly, Almodóvar doesn't attempt to romanticize the “tortured artist” in the grand, mythic tradition of Fellini. Instead, he strips that image bare, showing us not artistic crisis, but emotional crisis. The pain here is not one of dried-up inspiration—it's the aching back, the lost love, the aging body, the accumulated regrets of someone who has lived deeply and loved hard. It is about physical illness, addiction, memory, reconciliation—not with fame, but with self. This comes through both in the performance of the actors and, most memorably, through the reunion with an old lover. It's emotionally honest and moving. Secondly, the childhood flashbacks don't simply serve as explanatory devices for why the protagonist became a filmmaker. They're tender and vivid in their own right—particularly the scenes involving sexual awakening and early memories. They radiate a kind of warmth and innocence that makes the audience feel connected, rather than distanced by lofty artistic ambition.

What young filmmakers can truly learn from this film is how to treat memory



*“The nights that coincide several pains, those nights I believe in God and I pray to him. The days when I only suffer a type of pain I'm an atheist.”*



*"I thought the strength of my love would defeat his addiction. But it wasn't so. Love isn't enough to save the person you love."*

with care. Choosing which memories to show—and more importantly, how to show them—is a matter of sincerity, not grandeur. Almodóvar clearly understands this.

And finally, the brilliance of the film lies in its ending. The film-within-a-film twist is quietly profound: all those flashbacks we saw are in fact part of a film the protagonist is making in the present. This structure transforms the whole narrative into something self-reflexive and beautifully complete. It's clever without being clever for its own sake.

The rhythm of the film is elegant, and the use of color brings with it a certain noble serenity. I especially love the opening sequence—it immediately reminded me of the works of Gaudí, another Spanish artist who knew how to turn memory and emotion into form and space.

In a time where many self-reflective films stumble into narcissism, *Pain and Glory* stands tall. It doesn't posture.





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